

AP English Literature & Composition: The Complete Exam Guide

The poetry and prose multiple choice explained, the three literary essays, a close-reading playbook, and 10 hard practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.



3 hrs

1 hr multiple choice
+ 2 hrs essays

55+3

multiple-choice +
essays

55%

of your score comes
from the 3 essays

73–74%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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01 THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Two sections, one score

Your AP score (1–5) combines a multiple-choice section on poetry and prose passages with three literary analysis essays. The essays count for more than half your score.

45%

Section I • Multiple choice • 55 questions

55%

Section II • Free response • 3 essays

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
I • Multiple choice	45% of score 1 hour 55 questions	5 sets of 8–13 questions on passages of prose fiction, drama and poetry. At least 2 sets are prose and at least 2 are poetry.
II • Free response	55% of score 2 hours 3 essays	Poetry analysis • Prose fiction analysis • Literary argument: analyze a concept in a novel or play of your choice (from a list of about 40 suggested titles or a comparable work).

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

EACH ESSAY IS SCORED 0–6

Thesis, evidence and sophistication

Each essay earns up to **1 point for thesis**, **4 for evidence and commentary** and **1 for sophistication**. Your interpretation, supported by close reading, earns the points.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

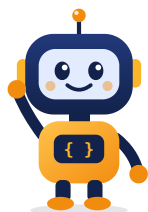
Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 15 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.



Pigo's tip: Prepare **3–4 novels or plays** you know deeply for the literary argument essay: characters, key scenes, themes and a few short quotations.

SECTION I

02 The multiple-choice section

55 questions in 60 minutes, a little over 1 minute each, including time to read five passages. Read actively and keep moving.

55

questions in 5 passage sets

~1:05

minutes per question, including reading

45%

of your total AP score

0

points lost for a wrong answer, so never leave one blank

How the passage sets are split

Five passage sets in total, with at least two of each kind.

Prose

Fiction or drama sets

≥ 2 sets

Poetry

Poem sets

≥ 2 sets

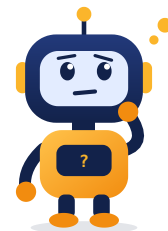
0%

What this means for your study time: Poetry is at least two of the five sets. Many students avoid poetry, so regular practice reading poems closely is one of the fastest ways to gain points.

Strategies that work on this section

- Read the whole passage first, marking shifts in tone, speaker or time.
- Answer "line" questions by rereading the lines plus one line before and after.
- Know your terms: apostrophe, enjambment, caesura, irony, paradox, unreliable narrator.
- Choose the most precise answer, not the one that is broadly true.
- Watch extreme tone words: "furious" and "ecstatic" are rarely right in literary passages.
- Pace yourself: about 12 minutes per passage set.

A **shift** (but, yet, now) often marks the key to a poem. Circle it on the first read.



03

WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The skills, in plain English

The course has 9 units rotating through short fiction, poetry and longer fiction or drama, all built around these six big ideas.

BIG IDEA

1

Character

Be ready to: explain how characters' choices, contradictions and changes reveal values and conflicts in the work.

BIG IDEA

2

Setting

Be ready to: explain how time, place and atmosphere shape characters and meaning.

BIG IDEA

3

Structure

Be ready to: analyze plot order, contrasts, shifts, and in poetry, line breaks, stanzas and form.

BIG IDEA

4

Narration

Be ready to: explain how point of view, narrator reliability and distance shape what readers know.

BIG IDEA

5

Figurative language

Be ready to: interpret imagery, metaphor, symbol, irony and how they build meaning.

BIG IDEA

6

Literary argumentation

Be ready to: write an interpretation with a defensible thesis, specific textual evidence and commentary.

Units at a glance: Short Fiction (Units 1, 4, 7) · Poetry (Units 2, 5, 8) · Longer Fiction or Drama (Units 3, 6, 9). Each cycle goes deeper into the same skills.

SECTION II

04 The 3 essays

2 hours for three essays, about 40 minutes each. Each essay is scored out of 6 with the same rubric rows.

Poetry • 6 pts

Prose • 6 pts

Literary argument • 6 pts

Each essay: thesis (1) + evidence & commentary (4) + sophistication (1)

Q1

Poetry analysis

~40 minutes

Analyze how a poet uses literary elements and techniques to convey a complex idea, such as a speaker's conflicted feelings.

Track how the poem changes from beginning to end.

Q2

Prose fiction analysis

~40 minutes

Analyze how an author uses literary elements to develop a character, relationship or idea in a passage.

Focus on two or three choices that build one interpretation.

Q3

Literary argument

~40 minutes

Choose a novel or play and argue how a concept from the prompt (such as a character's isolation) contributes to the work's meaning.

Prepare works you know well; specific scenes beat plot summary.

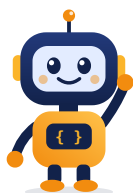
♦ A time plan for the 120 minutes

Poetry
40 min

Prose
40 min

Literary argument
40 min

Spend 5–8 minutes of each block reading and planning before you write.



Your thesis should answer **"so what?"**: what the details reveal about the work's meaning.

05 FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

Anatomy of a strong paragraph

Here is an original practice poem and a strong analysis paragraph, annotated to show where points come from.

PRACTICE TASK • WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice prompt (Q1 style): In the following poem, the speaker reflects on a grandmother's habit. Analyze how the poet uses literary elements and techniques to convey the speaker's changing understanding. *Inventory* My grandmother kept her buttons in a tin that once held biscuits from a country she had left. Brass ones, bone ones, one shaped like a star, each saved from coats that no one wore again. She never sewed them back. She only sorted: by size, by color, by the year they fell. When I was small I thought she loved the buttons. Now I think she was counting what was lost.

Sample analysis paragraph

- ① The poem's final stanza turns on a **shift in time**: "When I was small" against "Now I think," marking the speaker's movement from a child's view to an adult's.
- ② The child reads the sorting literally, as love of buttons, but the adult recognizes the buttons as **symbols** of coats "no one wore again," and of people and a homeland left behind.
- ③ Even the biscuit tin, from "a country she had left," quietly connects the collection to migration and loss.
- ④ By ending on the word "lost," the poet reframes the title's "inventory" as an act of mourning, showing that the speaker now understands grief that was hidden in ordinary habits.

- ① **Name the technique** and quote it precisely.
- ② **Interpret the symbol** at two levels.
- ③ **Use a small detail** to deepen the reading.
- ④ **Connect to meaning**, which is the "so what" that earns sophistication.

Five habits for every essay

- 1** Underline every task verb in the prompt before you plan.
- 2** Write a defensible thesis in your first paragraph.
- 3** Back every claim with specific evidence, then explain it.
- 4** Keep 2 minutes to reread and fix unclear sentences.
- 5** Stuck? Answer each part separately in order. Partial credit is real.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

The speaker **is** the poet! (Not necessarily.)



01 Speaker = poet

Refer to "the speaker" in poems and "the narrator" in prose. They are not automatically the author.

02 Plot summary

Retelling what happens isn't analysis. Explain how a detail creates meaning.

03 Device lists

"The poet uses imagery, diction and tone" earns nothing without explaining effects.

04 Vague thesis

"The author uses literary devices to convey meaning" restates the prompt. Name the meaning.

05 Ignoring shifts

Changes in tone, time or perspective are often the key to a passage.

06 Unprepared literary argument

Choosing a work you barely remember leads to vague evidence. Prepare 3–4 works.

07 Movie memories

Film versions often change plots. Use evidence from the text itself.

08 Long quotes

Short, embedded quotations followed by commentary work better than long block quotes.

09 Overreading

Interpretations must be supported by the text; avoid claims the passage can't back up.

10 Running out of time

Three complete essays score better than two polished and one unfinished.

Quick self-check: in the practice prose passage on the questions page, what does the principal parking in the visitor space suggest about him? (He doesn't yet feel he belongs, or isn't ready to claim his role.)

07

PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Read every day, and write one timed essay every two weeks.



- Sep – Oct**
Short fiction + poetry
 - Units 1–2**
Character, setting and basic poetic analysis. Annotate one short story and one poem each week.
- Nov – Dec**
Longer works
 - Unit 3 + your essay works**
Start building notes on 3–4 novels or plays for the literary argument essay.
- Jan – Feb**
Deeper analysis
 - Units 4–6**
Narration, structure and figurative language. Timed poetry and prose essays every two weeks.
- Mar – Apr**
Complexity
 - Units 7–9** sophistication
Irony, paradox and ambiguity. Practice multiple-choice passage sets under timing.
- Early May**
Sharpen
 - Full timed sections**
All three essays in one sitting. Review your notes on prepared works.
- Exam day**
May
 - AP Lit exam • Bluebook**
Sleep well, charge your device, and use the checklist at the end of this guide.

• The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: two passage sets and one timed essay	Name your weakest essay type
3 weeks out	Two timed essays of your weakest type	Commentary after every quote
2 weeks out	Full 3-hour practice exam	Finish all three essays
Final week	Light review: prepared works, terms, rubric	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF

10 practice questions

Original passages and questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Give yourself **15 minutes**, then check page 11.

1 POETRY • STRUCTURE

Questions 1–5 refer to the original poem below.

Inventory

My grandmother kept her buttons in a tin
that once held biscuits from a country she had left.
Brass ones, bone ones, one shaped like a star,
each saved from coats that no one wore again.
She never sewed them back. She only sorted:
by size, by color, by the year they fell.
When I was small I thought she loved the buttons.
Now I think she was counting what was lost.

Original poem written by ACT SAT GO for practice

The shift between lines 7 and 8 ("When I was small... / Now I think...") primarily emphasizes:

- A the difference between a child's and an adult's understanding
- B the speaker's growing frustration with the grandmother
- C a change in the poem's setting from city to country
- D the speaker's decision to sew the buttons back on

2 POETRY • SYMBOL

In the poem, the buttons function most clearly as symbols of:

- A wealth and status
- B the grandmother's talent for sewing
- C the speaker's childhood toys
- D people and a past that are gone

3 POETRY • DETAIL

The detail that the tin "once held biscuits from a country she had left" (line 2) mainly serves to:

- A suggest the grandmother's love of cooking
- B show that the family was wealthy
- C link the collection to migration and loss
- D introduce a humorous tone

4 POETRY • TONE

The tone of the final line is best described as:

- A sentimental and cheerful
- B quietly sorrowful
- C bitter and accusing
- D detached and clinical

5 POETRY • SYNTAX

The short sentence "She never sewed them back." (line 5) mainly:

- A criticizes the grandmother for laziness
- B introduces a new character
- C explains how buttons are made
- D emphasizes that the buttons were kept, not used

08 TEST YOURSELF (continued)

6 PROSE • CHARACTERIZATION

Questions 6–10 refer to the original passage below.

The new principal arrived on a Tuesday, which everyone agreed was the wrong day. Mondays were for beginnings and Fridays for endings; Tuesdays belonged to nobody. He parked in the visitor space, though his name was already painted on the curb beside it, and stood for a long minute looking at the building as if it might change its mind about him. Mrs. Okafor, who had run the front office for nineteen years and three principals, watched him through the blinds and decided to wait and see whether he would knock.

Original passage written by ACT SAT GO for practice

The principal's choice to park in the visitor space, "though his name was already painted on the curb beside it," most strongly suggests that he:

- A did not notice the sign
- B feels uncertain about claiming his new position
- C wants to show off to the staff
- D plans to leave the school quickly

7 PROSE • NARRATION

The statement that "everyone agreed" Tuesday was "the wrong day" is best described as:

- A an objective fact about the school calendar
- B the principal's own opinion
- C a humorous reflection of the staff's shared, superstitious judgment
- D foreshadowing of a disaster

8 PROSE • FIGURATIVE LANGUAGE

The phrase "as if it might change its mind about him" is an example of:

- A personification
- B hyperbole
- C alliteration
- D understatement

9 PROSE • CHARACTER

The detail that Mrs. Okafor had served "three principals" mainly establishes her as:

- A new and inexperienced
- B experienced and cautious about newcomers
- C eager to retire
- D hostile toward all leaders

10 PROSE • STRUCTURE

The passage ends with Mrs. Okafor deciding "to wait and see whether he would knock." This ending primarily creates:

- A resolution of the conflict
- B a flashback to an earlier principal
- C a moral lesson about kindness
- D suspense about how the relationship will begin



CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	A	"When I was small" and "Now I think" contrast two stages of understanding: the child sees a hobby; the adult sees grief.
2	D	The buttons come from coats "no one wore again," suggesting people (and a former life) that are gone.
3	C	The tin connects the collection to a homeland left behind, extending the theme of loss to migration.
4	B	"Counting what was lost" is understated but mournful, a quiet sorrow rather than bitterness.
5	D	The blunt sentence stresses that the buttons were never used again, preparing for the reinterpretation as a record of loss.
6	B	Avoiding the space with his own name implies hesitation about stepping into his role.
7	C	The narrator reports a collective, slightly comic belief about days of the week, not an objective fact.
8	A	Giving the building the ability to "change its mind" is personification, reflecting the principal's anxiety.
9	B	Nineteen years and three principals show long experience and explain her wary, watchful attitude.
10	D	The open ending leaves readers wondering how the relationship will begin, creating suspense.

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Read one short poem a day and write two sentences on how it changes.

10

KNOW THE TARGET

How students score

In recent years, about 73–74% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP English Literature and Composition, and about 16% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

73–74%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

16%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ Plan your time: **~12 min** per multiple-choice passage set; **40 min** per essay
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Review your notes on **3–4 prepared novels or plays**
- ☐ Practice typing a full essay in 40 minutes before exam day

In the essays: state an interpretation that answers "so what?", use short embedded quotations, follow every quote with commentary on its effect, and trace how the work develops its meaning from beginning to end.



ACT SAT GO • 1-ON-1 AP TUTORING

Aiming for a 5? Get a personal AP Lit plan.

Book a free diagnostic lesson. We'll find your weakest units, review your practice responses, and give you a week-by-week plan to exam day in May.

Book a free diagnostic lesson →



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